

Evaluating the Mobile and Web Experience for Uber Reserve

A usability testing case study comparing how users understand, reserve, and cancel scheduled rides across mobile and desktop.

Uber Reserve allows riders to book upcoming trips in advance. For this sponsored student UX research project, my team evaluated the Uber Reserve experience across mobile and web to understand how users discovered the feature, interpreted its purpose, reserved a ride, and canceled an upcoming trip.

The study combined exploratory survey data, usability testing, qualitative analysis, and standardized usability metrics including NPS, UMUX-Lite, and SUS.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: Uber Reserve sponsored UX research project

Timeline: October 2021 – December 2021

Role: Student UX Researcher

Team / Stakeholders: 4 student researchers, project stakeholders / evaluators

Problem Space: Evaluating whether users understood, reserved, and canceled Uber Reserve rides successfully across mobile and web

Methods: Exploratory survey, moderated usability testing, think-aloud protocol, semi-structured interviews, task analysis, NPS, UMUX-Lite, SUS

Tools: Zoom, Google Forms, Miro

Outputs: Research plan, usability test sessions, findings synthesis, platform comparison, usability metrics, prioritized recommendations, and [final presentation](#)

Outcome / Impact: Delivered six research-backed recommendations to improve feature awareness, consistency, date/time selection, upcoming trip management, and web/mobile usability

Focus Areas: Evaluative research, usability testing, mobile UX, web UX, transportation UX, metrics-based research

The Challenge

Uber Reserve had been introduced as a way for users to book rides up to 30 days in advance.

The feature had clear potential value, especially for situations where users wanted more peace of mind — such as early morning trips, airport rides, or planned events. However, our exploratory survey showed that awareness was low: **90.7% of survey participants did not know what Uber Reserve was.**

This created a key research challenge:

Do users understand what Uber Reserve is, when they would use it, and how to successfully reserve and cancel a ride across mobile and web?

Research Questions

Our study focused on five research questions:

Do users understand the purpose of Uber Reserve?

What is effective or ineffective about the current Reserve experience?

Which scenarios are most useful for mobile versus desktop?

Which scenarios is Reserve most useful for?

What flow do people take when reserving a ride?

These questions helped us evaluate not only task completion, but also mental model, platform expectations, feature awareness, and usefulness.

Method

We conducted 10 recorded usability sessions using a semi-structured think-aloud format.

Participants completed two core tasks on both mobile and web:

Reserve a ride one week in advance

Cancel the reserved ride

To compare platform experiences, we alternated whether participants started on mobile or web.

During and after the tasks, we collected qualitative feedback and usability metrics, including:

NPS
UMUX-Lite
SUS

Participants were recruited through a Google Form and represented a range of ages, locations, and professions. In the usability sample, 90% were Uber users and 60% worked in tech.

What Worked Well

The core reservation flow was intuitive.

All participants were able to successfully reserve a ride across mobile and web. Many described the process as easier or smoother than expected.

Users saw value in the feature.

Participants understood the emotional benefit of planning ahead, especially the peace of mind that comes from knowing transportation is scheduled.

The web experience had planning strengths.

Participants appreciated the larger map and route visualization on desktop, especially for planning ahead, reviewing trip details, or capturing information for later.

The mobile experience was preferred overall.

Most participants preferred mobile because it felt familiar, convenient, and aligned with how they typically use Uber.

Key Findings

1. The Uber Reserve mental model was unclear.

Eight out of ten participants had confusion around the name or purpose of Uber Reserve. Some did not know the service was called Reserve, while others associated the word “reserve” with a different time horizon or expectation.

This showed that the issue was not only usability — it was also feature comprehension and naming.

2. Bugs, inconsistencies, and localization issues affected trust.

Eight out of ten participants encountered or noticed inconsistencies across mobile, web, and regional versions of the experience.

These included incorrect text descriptions, unexpected sign-in behavior, different feature availability by location, and differences between web and mobile flows.

3. Upcoming rides were hard to find and manage.

Six out of ten participants experienced confusion around upcoming rides, especially when trying to cancel a reserved trip on mobile.

Some users expected to see language like “My reservations,” while the interface used labels such as “Rides” and “Trips,” creating uncertainty about where to go.

4. Date and time selection created friction.

Six out of ten participants struggled with date or time selection. Issues included inconsistent patterns between mobile and desktop, confusion around AM/PM selection, and expectations for a more familiar calendar view.

5. Mobile and web each had distinct strengths.

Participants generally preferred mobile for convenience and familiarity, but they also saw value in web for planning, viewing the route on a larger map, and saving trip details.

6. The overall experience tested well, but still had clear opportunities.

The feature was useful and generally usable, but the research revealed opportunities to improve awareness, consistency, terminology, and planning flows.

Quantitative Results

The usability metrics supported the qualitative findings.

NPS

Mobile: 30

Web: 22

UMUX-Lite

Mobile usefulness: 97%

Mobile usability: 89%

Web usefulness: 95%

Web usability: 80%

SUS

Mobile: 83

Web: 78

These results suggested that users found both platforms useful, but mobile performed slightly better across preference and usability measures.

Recommendations

Based on our findings, we delivered six research-backed recommendations.

1. Minimize differences within regional user groups.

Users should have a more consistent Reserve experience across locations where possible. Differences in feature availability or interface behavior can create confusion and reduce trust.

2. Increase user awareness.

Because many participants did not know Uber Reserve existed, we recommended improving awareness through ads, onboarding, or feature education.

3. Increase feature visibility.

Reserve should be easier to discover within the Uber experience, especially for scenarios where planning ahead is likely valuable.

4. Improve date and time selection.

We recommended making the date and time picker more intuitive and consistent across mobile and web, including clearer calendar patterns and simpler AM/PM selection.

5. Continue adding organizational benefits.

Users saw value in Reserve for planning. We recommended continuing to support use cases where people may want receipts, trip details, route visibility, or confirmation for planned travel.

6. Declutter the web interface.

While desktop had strengths, the web interface could be simplified to reduce distraction and help users focus on trip planning and reservation details.

Reflection

This project gave me hands-on experience designing and conducting a usability study from start to finish.

I learned how to structure a moderated usability session, facilitate think-aloud testing, compare mobile and web experiences in the same study, and combine qualitative observations with usability metrics.

The project also taught me the importance of testing mental models, not just flows. Uber Reserve was generally usable once participants found it, but many users did not fully understand the feature, name, or where it fit into the broader Uber experience.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were running this study now, I would recruit a broader range of ages and technical comfort levels. Because 60% of the usability participants worked in tech, the sample may have skewed toward people who are more comfortable navigating digital products.

I would also separate the mobile and web usability tests more cleanly to reduce learning effects between platforms.

Finally, I would align the study with Uber-specific product metrics if available, such as Reserve discovery rate, booking conversion, cancellation success, support requests, or repeat usage.

Project Card

Evaluating the Mobile and Web Experience for Uber Reserve

Conducted usability testing across Uber Reserve mobile and web experiences with 10 participants, supported by exploratory survey data from 66 respondents. Analyzed task success, mental models, NPS, UMUX-Lite, and SUS to deliver six recommendations for improving feature awareness, consistency, date/time selection, and trip management.

UX Research · Usability Testing · Evaluative Research · Mobile UX · Web UX · NPS ·
UMUX-Lite · SUS · Task Analysis · Think-Aloud Testing · Product Recommendations ·
Transportation UX